MONDAY
October 26, 2026
UPSC EDITION
20 Pages

IndiaGS Daily

CIVIL SERVICES CURRENT AFFAIRS · FILTERED FOR THE UPSC SYLLABUS

Vol. 1 · No. 3
indiags.com
Source: The Indian Express (New Delhi), 26.10.2026

POLITY · PG 3–5 EDUCATION · PG 6–7 INTERNATIONAL · PG 8–9 ECONOMY · PG 10–13 ENVIRONMENT · PG 14–15 SCI-TECH & SECURITY · PG 16–17 EDITORIAL · PG 18–19 PRELIMS · PG 20

IN BRIEF



Last day of Delhi SIR camp

At a Special Intensive Revision camp inside an MCD-run school in east Delh the last day of such camps held by the Election Commission across the Ca the rolls in the SIR. ABHINAV SAHA REPORT, PAGE 6

LAST DAY — A Special Intensive Revision camp inside an MCD-run school in east Delhi's Chilla Village on Sunday, the last of the camps held by the Election Commission across the Capital. ABHINAV SAHA

Creamy layer: Centre awaits SC directions on CSE allocation

Service allocation for 958 candidates recommended by the UPSC for CSE-2025 is held up pending clarification of the March 11 judgment on the OBC creamy-layer test. **Pg 4**

Arlekar moved to oust Kerala PSC chief

The former Governor recommended removal of the State Public Service Commission chairperson days before leaving for Tamil Nadu, raising an Article 317 question. **Pg 4**

Op Trident unearths narco-hawala network

Raids across Assam, Mizoram and Manipur led to 18 arrests, the freezing of 1,424 accounts and detection of ₹100 crore in hawala transactions. **Pg 16**

No permanent geographic split of fighter assets

The Air Chief Marshal says theaterisation must follow "centralised control where necessary, decentralised execution where appropriate". **Pg 16**

Loss and Damage Fund promises $20 mn to Nepal

The first allocation from the FRLD since it became operational — small against $4.75 billion in estimated needs, but a template for future claims. **Pg 14**

Odisha braces for very severe cyclone

Landfall is expected near the Andhra coast on October 28 with winds of 115–125 kmph; 60 ODRAF and 17 NDRF teams deployed. **Pg 14**

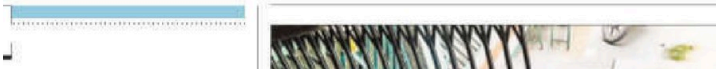
LEAD · GS III INTERNAL SECURITY & GS II GOVERNANCE

Wars target economies, must protect India's banking from cyber terror: PM

Modern wars are not fought with weapons alone but by targeting economies, the Prime Minister said while inaugurating the RBI's data centre and Cybersecurity Training Institute in Bhubaneswar



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, RBI Governor Sanjay Malh and Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi in Bhubaneswar, Sunday. PTI



BHUBANESWAR — The Prime Minister with Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra and Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi. PTI

Warning that modern wars are not fought with weapons alone but also by targeting economies, the Prime Minister on Sunday underlined the need to protect India's banking system from "cyber terrorists".

"We all understand that modern warfare is not waged solely with weapons. Weakening a country can also be attempted by striking at its economy. As India gains financial strength, safeguarding our banking system against cyber criminals and cyber terrorists is equally imperative," he said.

"The nature of cyber threats is evolving today. We cannot counter such emerging challenges using outdated training modules, or legacy tools. This necessitates modern infrastructure alongside skilled human resources. It is precisely here that the role of this new Cybersecurity Training Institute becomes critically important."

The remarks come amid recent cybersecurity-related incidents at prominent organisations, with artificial intelligence-aided fears compounding concerns. Earlier this week, the country's largest public sector lender acknowledged that personal data of some of its customers was exposed on the dark web, including mobile numbers, addresses and loan details.

Last week, the Indian Computer Emergency Response Team said that AI agents had gained unauthorised access to live systems of Indian organisations, and their recorded activity involved accessing business records, including personal data and confidential material, through credentials exposed in application configurations, public code repositories and permissive cloud service roles.

WHY IT MATTERS — Critical information infrastructure and the financial sector; CERT-In's mandate; AI agents as a new attack surface; cyber warfare as a non-traditional security threat. Pair with the DPDP Act timeline for a complete GS III answer on data security.

EXPRESS SPECIAL · GS III ECONOMY

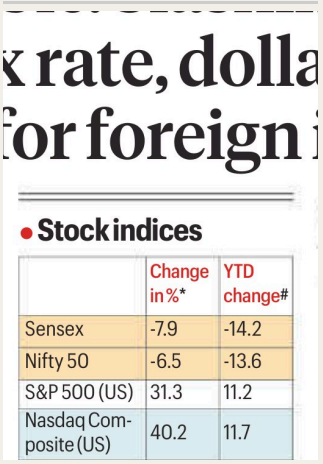
On the FM's table: slashing capital gains tax, dollar-based taxation for foreign investors

Flat markets for two years a concern

As investors grapple with a flat stock market trajectory for more than two years, discussions within the government in the run-up to Budget 2027-28 include lowering the long-term capital gains tax rate from 12.5% now for both domestic and foreign investors, and letting foreign investors pay this tax on capital gains made in **dollar terms** as opposed to in rupee terms, to boost market sentiment.

Officials say the urgency to act fast is due to two key concerns. One, zero returns or losses in stock markets over the last two years come on top of poor wage growth, and this is a big sentiment dampener. It is felt across a larger spectrum of the middle class, where post-Covid retail investment witnessed a sharp rise.

STOCK INDICES — CHANGE OVER LAST TWO YEARS



x rate, dolla
for foreign i

Stock indices

	Change in %*	YTD change#
Sensex	-7.9	-14.2
Nifty 50	-6.5	-13.6
S&P 500 (US)	31.3	11.2
Nasdaq Composite (US)	40.2	11.7

Sensex −7.9% and Nifty 50 −6.5% over two years, against gains in the Nasdaq Composite (+40.2%), FTSE 100 (+29.3%) and Bovespa (+57.9%).

The depreciation problem. Section 72 of the Income-tax Act, 2025 deals with the mode of computation of capital gains: income chargeable under the head is computed after full consideration of a capital asset after deducting transfer expenses, acquisition costs and improvement costs. Foreign currency conversion benefits are provided to non-residents under section 72(6) for transferring unlisted Indian company shares or debentures — to prevent notional gains caused by rupee depreciation. This relief does not explicitly apply to non-residents and excludes domestic investors and FPIs.

WHY IT MATTERS — Capital gains taxation (LTCG/STCG), Securities Transaction Tax, FPI flows and the rupee; the tax-versus-sentiment trade-off in Budget-making. Note the policy question: should the tax base be nominal rupee gains or real dollar gains?

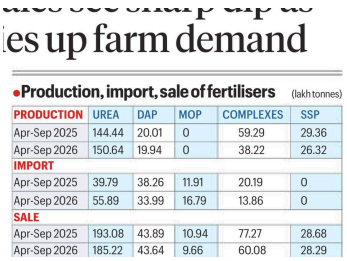
GS III · AGRICULTURE

Fertiliser sales see a sharp dip as El Niño dries up farm demand

Tractor sales also down 18.1% in September amid a festival calendar shift

In what could be a real indicator of deficient rains and the El Niño effect on farms, domestic sales of all fertilisers — including urea — are down compared to last year. Sales for April–September 2026 over the same period of 2025 roughly coincide with the *kharif* planting season; the drop has been the sharpest at **22.2%** for complex fertilisers containing nitrogen, phosphorus, potassium and sulphur. Urea sales are **4.1%** down year on year, marking the first dip after 2021-22 and from the record 39.6 million tonnes of 2025-26.

"The main reason is poor rains across the southern states, Maharashtra's Marathwada and Vidarbha, Saurashtra and Kutch in Gujarat, Rajasthan, south Bihar and Assam. It has led to lower demand from farmers," an industry source said. Rainfall during the southwest monsoon was **12.6% below the normal long-period average**.



●Production, import, sale of fertilisers (lakh tonnes)

PRODUCTION	UREA	DAP	MOP	COMPLEXES	SSP
Apr-Sep 2025	144.44	20.01	0	59.29	29.36
Apr-Sep 2026	150.64	19.94	0	38.22	26.32
IMPORT					
Apr-Sep 2025	39.79	38.26	11.91	20.19	0
Apr-Sep 2026	55.89	33.99	16.79	13.86	0
SALE					
Apr-Sep 2025	193.08	43.89	10.94	77.27	28.68
Apr-Sep 2026	185.22	43.64	9.66	60.08	28.29

PRODUCTION, IMPORT AND SALE OF FERTILISERS (lakh tonnes) — April–September 2025 against April–September 2026. Source: The Fertiliser Association of India.

WHY IT MATTERS — Monsoon dependence and input demand as a leading indicator; the Nutrient Based Subsidy regime and the N:P:K imbalance; the Strait of Hormuz disruption pushing up sulphur and DAP import costs. See the soil health analysis on Page 7.

GS II · RIGHTS & ACCOUNTABILITY

She never went to school, but took officials to the SC over husband's 'custodial death'

Lehra Bai, 35, was not present in person when the Supreme Court came down hard on the Chhattisgarh Director General (Prisons) and Principal Secretary (Home) for their handling of her case, calling their actions "sacrilegious" and their claims "patently false and wholly reprehensible".

It took a fight of more than two years, but the 35-year-old mother of two, who never went to school, had made her voice heard, ensuring that the death of her husband, allegedly in custody, did not go unacknowledged. The Court directed the State to pay her interim compensation of **₹25 lakh**, ordered a CBI inquiry, and said that a criminal case be registered against the guilty officials.

WHY IT MATTERS — Custodial deaths and Article 21; NHRC guidelines on custodial death reporting; compensation as a public-law remedy; access to justice for the rural poor. A strong GS II and GS IV illustration.

GS I · ART & CULTURE

Jogen Chowdhury, 1939–2026: he blended traditional imagery with contemporary style

A towering figure in modern Indian art, Jogen Chowdhury passed away on Sunday morning after a battle with blood cancer. Graduating from Kolkata's Government College of Art and Craft (1955-60), he trained in printmaking at the École Nationale Supérieure des Beaux-Arts, Paris (1965-67). He is best known for his fusion of traditional iconography with a contemporary sensibility.

"In his work the line works of the great Bengal tradition — Kalighat paintings and artists like Jamini Roy — merges with current socio-political realities to hold up a mirror to our current society," said the writer and curator Kishore Singh. His laborious cross-hatching technique created depth with it; the famous painting "Tiger in Moonlight" captivated him instantly. He was a Trinamool Congress Rajya Sabha MP from 2014 to 2020, and served as 'Keeper of Art' at Santiniketan.

WHY IT MATTERS — Modern Indian art movements; the Bengal School and Kalighat pat tradition; Santiniketan and Kala Bhavan as institutions. Personalities in news are a standing prelims category.

THE BIG STORY · ELECTORAL ROLLS

On the last day of SIR camps, BLOs wait, then go door to door

Delhi had around 1.45 crore electors before the revision began. After the draft roll was published on August 31, around 97.5 lakh names were retained, while around 47.5 lakh were classified as 'uncollectible'



At an SIR camp inside a government school in Delhi's Chilla Village, Sund

daughters had been issued notices for not being able to link themselves to the 2002 electoral

by the BLO at Chilla.

The BLO said that there are very few registered addresses in

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CHILLA VILLAGE — At an SIR camp inside a government school in east Delhi on Sunday. ABHINAV SAHA

At the MCD school in East Delhi's Chilla village, the Booth Level Officer said he had not received even a single Form 6 application to enrol new voters through the day. In New Moti Bagh, the BLO said he had visited 42 houses over five hours and got four Form 6 applications. In Sarai Kale Khan village, the BLO waited at the local MCD school "from morning around noon" with other BLOs, "but no one came" to get enrolled.

Even on the last day of the Election Commission's special camps being held across Delhi to enrol voters left out of the rolls in the Special Intensive Revision, BLOs mostly found themselves waiting for residents. The few that came forward, they said, were those who wanted help to resolve notices they were issued for not being able to link to the 2002 electoral roll.

Of the roughly 47.5 lakh classified as 'uncollectible' after BLOs found them to be ASDU — absent, shifted, deceased — or having duplicate entries, so far only around **4.7 lakh** people have applied to be included in the electoral roll through Form 6 applications in Delhi.

Why people are being asked to come to camps. "I was a voter then, but I don't remember any details and whether I was registered in Delhi or my village back then, which is why I did not fill that column," said one woman called to a camp. "The BLO said that there are very few registered addresses in the village. In the electoral rolls, in place of house numbers, most addresses of electors mention just 'CV' or 'Ch'. It is nearly impossible to locate electors in this area, that is why we are calling them to camps to resolve their notices," the BLO said.

The Commission's own count. A report published on September 23 revealed that Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had objected on record 14 times in 10 months to steps taken by the Commission under Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, including adding new voters and deleting names.

A test case. A 19-year-old who studies at a Noida college and recently became eligible to vote was among the few who had come to the camp to be enrolled. He had been easy to enrol — but the BLO got stuck at the declaration section that seeks the status of the applicant's parents *vis-à-vis* the last SIR. His father was not even in the BLO's list of electors. The BLO told him to get his father's Voter ID and, in the meanwhile, started looking for his father's name in lists of other BLOs.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Forms 6, 7 and 8 and the BLO–ERO–CEO chain; ASDU classification; the mapping of electors to the 2002 roll; dissent within a multi-member constitutional body. A near-certain GS II mains theme this cycle.

GS II · RIGHT TO PROTEST

'Won't stop till we get union': scuffles, tight security mark Jamia stir on Day 14

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NEW DELHI — Security arrangements were stepped up at the university on Sunday. TABSHIR SHAMS

Over 100 security personnel were on duty, students trying to enter the varsity by climbing walls covered in barbed wire and metal spikes, alleged scuffles between protesters and security personnel, rallies and sloganeering as protesters on hunger strike kept themselves locked inside the Department of Political Science to ensure that their fast could not be broken.

The main demand is the restoration of the Jamia Millia Islamia Students' Union with a fixed election date and schedule. The last time the university held a student union poll was in 2005.

Protesters have rejected the administration's proposal to draft a union constitution first and set a deadline for the process. "The sequence has to be followed: first a constitution, then the electoral roll, then the election date," an official said, adding that after a 20-year gap, and with the Lyngdoh Committee recommendations and University Grants Commission regulations having changed, this cannot be done in haste.

Students cited the Supreme Court's 2006 judgment in *University of Kerala v Council of Principals, Colleges, Kerala* and others, and the Lyngdoh Committee recommendations, to argue that drafting a constitution should not delay announcing elections.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — The Lyngdoh Committee recommendations and their statutory status; Article 19(1)(b) on campus; university autonomy versus democratic participation; UGC regulations on student bodies.

GS II · INSTITUTIONS

'Society survives by its institutions': former CJI Chandrachud

Warning against the growing erosion of institutional trust in modern democracy, former Chief Justice of India D Y Chandrachud said that "society survives by its institutions". Delivering a convocation address at a degree distribution ceremony, he urged graduating doctors to reject workplace exploitation and dedicate themselves to the unglamorous, foundational work of healthcare.

"You have attained this level of excellence because of the institution... because of what you have learned by way of experience in the institutional setting. Institutions make all the critical difference," he said.

Drawing a parallel between human anatomy and institutional building, he said: "A healed organ inside a body, and a foundation of an institution, has something in common: nobody sees them. The internal organ is only captured by scans... It lies buried and unthanked, and yet everyone stands on the foundation."

On work environments, he encouraged the younger generation to reject systemic exploitation as an acceptable norm, saying: "Some of it will feel unfair, and sometimes it will be unfair. I also, as a young lawyer, had to grow up on a prolonged period of exploitation. But understand what is happening to you. You are being remodelled. The very lines along which you struggle are the lines along which you will become strong."

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — GS IV: institutional integrity, workplace ethics, mentorship; GS II: public trust in institutions as a precondition for democratic functioning. Quotable material for essay papers.

GS II · PUBLIC PROCUREMENT

Action against 392 local body officials in Madhya Pradesh

Days after a video surfaced showing the Additional Chief Secretary warning urban local body officials that procurement irregularities would not be tolerated, the bureaucrat disclosed that action has been taken against 392 officials, including 135 Chief Municipal Officers.

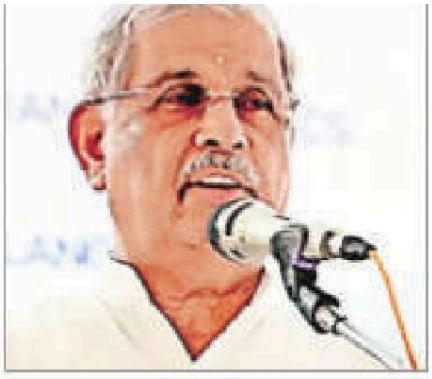
Seven officials have been dismissed from service and action taken against more than 80 contractors and suppliers, besides recovering **₹3-4 crore** from officials and employees over irregular payments. "The greater the irregularity and the more serious the negligence, the stronger the action taken against the person concerned," he said.

A presentation by the Additional Managing Director of the State Electronics Development Corporation cited purchases worth approximately **₹250 crore** made by 374 urban local bodies over three years, and estimated that around ₹250 crore could have been saved if purchases had been made at average prices — through the **Government e-Marketplace (GeM)**.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Public procurement reform and GeM; urban local bodies and the 74th Amendment; audit and accountability mechanisms at the municipal tier.

GS II · CONSTITUTIONAL OFFICES

Kerala: Arlekar's move to oust PSC chief kicks up a row over Article 317



Rajendra Arlekar

Opposition leader and former Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan termed the move "il-

Rajendra Arlekar, former Governor of Kerala.

Days before moving to Tamil Nadu this month, former Kerala Governor Rajendra Arlekar recommended to the President the removal of the State Public Service Commission chairperson and other members, sparking a political controversy amid an ongoing police inquiry into alleged recruitment irregularities at the commission.

The constitutional provision. Under **Article 317**, the authority to remove a State PSC chairperson or members rests with the President, who must refer the allegations to the Supreme Court for an inquiry. If the court's report supports the removal, the President can issue an order removing the chairperson or members. Under Article 316, the Constitution provides for a six-year term; removal must follow the procedure prescribed under Article 317.

The Opposition leader and former Chief Minister termed the move "illegal", calling it a violation of constitutional provisions. The Revenue Minister echoed this view: "The Governor's recommendation to the President without keeping the government informed or even taking it into confidence is a matter of grave concern. At the same time, I do not justify the PSC chairperson and members who are facing allegations."

"PSC members are appointed under Article 316 of the Constitution for a term of six years. Their removal must follow the procedure prescribed under Article 317. The Supreme Court should conduct a probe into the allegations, and the President can take further action only based on the court finding," a former member said.

WHY IT MATTERS — Articles 315–323 on Public Service Commissions; protected tenure as a guarantee of institutional independence; the Governor's discretionary communications with the President; recruitment-body integrity.

GS II · RESERVATION & THE CIVIL SERVICES

Creamy layer row: 'Centre awaiting SC directions for CSE service allocation'

Results of CSE-2025 were declared while service allocation for the examination was yet to be finalised

The Centre is awaiting directives from the Supreme Court on the implementation challenges arising from the top court's **March 11 judgment** concerning criteria for determining the creamy layer status of Other Backward Classes civil services candidates.

The Department of Personnel and Training has sought directions to allow the government to proceed with service allocation for the **958 candidates** recommended by the Union Public Service Commission for **CSE-2025** on the basis of the OBC creamy-layer determination applied before the March 11 verdict.

What the judgment held. In its verdict, the top court, among other things, held that "creamy layer" status for reservation cannot be decided solely based on parental income and treating similarly placed employees of private entities and public sector undertakings differently from government employees, for deciding reservation, would amount to hostile discrimination.

In view of the challenges, on August 24 the department filed a Miscellaneous Application with the top court, seeking clarification and directions on implementation of the judgment. Since service allocation is difficult to undo once made, the DoPT has sought directions from the Supreme Court before proceeding further.

The matter required holistic examination in consultation with stakeholders, including the UPSC, the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment, and the Ministry of Law and Justice. The exercise also involved collating data of candidates across fourteen CSE years and assessing the implications for existing seniority, potential cascading claims, and the OBC reservation policy across the country. Results of CSE-2025 were declared on **March 6** — five days before the judgment was delivered.

WHY IT MATTERS — The creamy layer doctrine from *Indra Sawhney* (1992) onwards; income versus status-based exclusion; administrative consequences of a judgment delivered mid-process. Directly about the examination the reader is writing — worth knowing precisely.

GS II · INTER-STATE DISPUTES

Odisha and Andhra's decades-old dispute over a panchayat is back in focus



A 25-member BJD delegation also visited Kotia on Friday to assess the situation. EXPRESS

act with residents.

The BJP hit back at Patnaik,

his 24-year tenure.

"They neither resolved the

KOTIA — A 25-member BJD delegation visited the disputed villages on Friday to assess the situation. EXPRESS

Andhra Pradesh's move to hold local body elections in three villages in the disputed Kotia panchayat has reignited a long-standing boundary dispute.

The geography. Kotia comprises a cluster of **28 villages** with a population of nearly 5,000. Since the 1960s, Odisha and Andhra Pradesh have both claimed jurisdiction over 21 of these villages. Residents of the panchayat receive welfare benefits from both States, but the unresolved dispute over jurisdiction has left them caught between competing administrative claims, raising questions about their identity and the certainty of governance.

The legal history. Odisha has already moved the Supreme Court, seeking contempt action against Andhra Pradesh over its notification to hold local body polls. The dispute goes back to **1968**, when Odisha challenged Andhra Pradesh's interference in the region. On **March 30, 2006**, the Supreme Court dismissed Odisha's petition on technical grounds and again directed the two States to maintain the status quo. In March 2023 Odisha approached the Supreme Court again, arguing that the disputed region had been included in Odisha's Pottangi block in Koraput district in the 2011 Census. It also cited Odisha's collection of land revenue from the villages.

In November 2021, the State's Chief Minister met his Andhra Pradesh counterpart, and both sought to establish a joint institutional mechanism to resolve various bilateral issues.

WHY IT MATTERS — Article 131 and the Supreme Court's original jurisdiction; inter-State boundary disputes; dual enrolment and dual benefits as an administrative anomaly; the limits of judicial status-quo orders.

GS II · POLITICAL DISCOURSE

A remark, a row, and the question of parliamentary decorum



Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge with party's Bihar unit chief Rajesh Ram and MP Akhilesh Prasad Singh in Patna on Sunday. ANI

PATNA — The Congress president with the party's Bihar unit chief and an MP on Sunday. ANI

A remark by the Congress president at a Patna event on Sunday triggered a political row, with the ruling party and its allies condemning the language as "abusive". The Union Home Minister accused the Congress chief of having breached "all norms of decorum", and a nationwide protest was announced.

The Congress leader was speaking at a programme marking the 139th birth anniversary of Bihar's first Chief Minister, Sri Krishna Singh, popularly known as Shri Babu. He later said his statement had been cut short, leading to the misunderstanding, and added that he meant to say that unless there are widespread protests against the ruling establishment, it will not go anywhere.

In his speech, he also targeted the Election Commission, accusing it of facilitating untouchability, and raised the issue of the 2023 law on the appointment of the CEC and Election Commissioners, which he said granted election commissioners sweeping legal immunity.

WHY IT MATTERS — GS IV: probity and civility in public life; GS II: the 2023 Act on CEC appointment and the immunity question; political mobilisation around electoral administration.

GS I · ELECTORAL HISTORY

Bengal's controversial 1972 election, and why it is back in the argument

More than five decades after one of West Bengal's most controversial Assembly elections, the 1972 polls are back in the spotlight, with allegations of large-scale rigging, violence against political workers and suppression of electoral competition.

The result. The Congress won **216 of the 280 seats**, while its ally the Communist Party of India secured 35. The CPI(M), which had won 113 seats in the 1971 Assembly election, was reduced to just 14. The Left had contested the election in an alliance with several parties, making its electoral rout all the more striking.

The contested count. Yet the tally concealed a more complicated picture of popular support. In an article published in the *Economic and Political Weekly* on April 15, 1972, the CPI(M) leader Biplab Dasgupta argued that the result bore little relation to its share of the vote: the CPI(M) had secured about 28% of the vote, marginally below the Congress's 29% in the 1971 election. He pointed to the absence of a uniform swing against the CPI(M).

The Election Commission recorded disturbances at several polling stations. Opposition parties then alleged large-scale rigging in many constituencies. The poll panel, however, recorded very few formal complaints from voters who claimed they had been prevented from voting. The CPI(M) denounced the result and stayed away from the legislature for much of the Assembly's term, terming it a "semi-fascist takeover".

WHY IT MATTERS — Post-Independence political history; the credibility of electoral processes as a recurring theme; first-past-the-post and the vote-share versus seat-share gap. Useful for both GS I history and GS II electoral reform answers.

GS II · INTERNAL SECURITY

'State cannot achieve lasting peace as long as gun culture exists': Manipur CM

BRIEFLY



The Chief Minister during an inspection of a camp in Kangpokpi district on Sunday. PTI

The Manipur Chief Minister visited a designated camp for militants under the Suspension of Operations agreement in Kangpokpi district on Sunday. The Central Reserve Police Force took over the camp following joint operations involving the CRPF, the Assam Rifles unit and the police, in the aftermath of the killing of three firewood collectors near a camp.

The Chief Minister inspected the camp premises and was briefed by CRPF and Assam Rifles officers on recent operations. Interacting with senior security officers and personnel, he commended the CRPF's CoBRA Battalion for its leading role in the operation.

"Manipur cannot progress or achieve lasting peace as long as gun culture exists," he said, appealing to the people to shun violence, surrender illegal arms and work collectively towards restoring peace and harmony in the State.

WHY IT MATTERS — Suspension of Operations agreements and their monitoring; CRPF, CoBRA and Assam Rifles mandates; arms recovery and the challenge of restoring the State's monopoly on legitimate force.

HARDLOOK · GS II EDUCATION

The fourth-year trap

About 4,000 students from Delhi University's first four-year undergraduate batch have no seat in the one-year master's course they were promised. A lost year, and students now asking the Delhi High Court for a way forward



AURAV SHARMA (21) did Hindi Honours with research at Kirori Mal Col- The fourth-year food, Rs 2,000 on travel to classes an 2,000-3,000 on miscellaneous items. O vear. that comes to roughlv Rs 1.81-1.931

DELHI UNIVERSITY — Students of the first four-year undergraduate batch, many of whom are now before the High Court. ABHINAV SAHA / PRAVEEN KHANNA

One student did Hindi Honours with research at a Delhi University college and was among the higher scorers in his batch. This year he could not get into the university's one-year master's programme, and is now taking a part-time course in Portuguese. Had he been on track, he would be closer to his goal of becoming an assistant professor. The National Education Policy's one-year master's was meant to save him a year before applying for a PhD or appearing for NET. Instead, he is before the Delhi High Court, waiting for a way ahead.

He is one of roughly 4,000 students from the first four-year undergraduate batch who are in limbo, with no certainty of a seat in the one-year master's course under the NEP. They have already lost the academic year 2026-27. At least 50-60 of them have been before the Delhi High Court since August, challenging how the university chose who gets in.

The numbers. According to the dean of admissions, around **2.5 lakh** students applied in 2022, when the university adopted the NEP structure, for the 72,600-odd seats on offer. Around **23,000** continued to the fourth year in 2025, while the rest graduated with a three-year degree. Roughly **14,000** have applied for the one-year PG programme.

"We were not anticipating that so many would opt to continue with academics and it is an extremely welcome change," the dean said. The university has only about **3,000** seats for the programme, including School of Open Learning seats. About 1,800 students are now admitted in the regular course.

'We were told it was a lucrative pathway.' In 2022, DU admitted its first batch under the NEP 2020's Undergraduate Curriculum Framework. It was a four-year degree, followed by a one-year master's. Students could do four years of Honours with a single discipline, or a four-year bachelor's with a Major in a multidisciplinary course. They could also exit after three years with a bachelor's degree, and with Honours if they had studied a single discipline. A little less than half of those admitted in 2022 chose to continue into the fourth year.

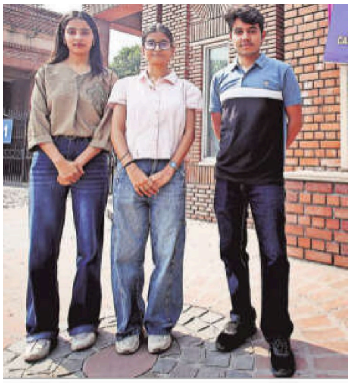
"We saw value in the four-year programme, thinking that it comprises a research component. At the end of third year, when we had an option to choose whether we want to continue with the fourth year or exit with an Honours degree, our professors advised and encouraged us to opt for the four-year course, assuring us that it is a lucrative pathway," one student said.

The rules that arrived after the exams. On **July 4**, DU offered its first-ever one-year postgraduate programme under NEP 2020: around 1,000-odd seats for nearly 23,000 graduates of its four-year courses. Students say the seats were too few, and that by the time the bulletin was issued, several other universities had closed their admissions. On **July 31**, the university revised the seat matrix to around 2,500, which also fell short.

Double the work, and still behind. One student did a multidisciplinary BSc at a DU college, with a Major in Electronics and minors in physics and math. He had to complete 50 credits over four years; students who exited after three years had to complete 24. "That's covering double the credits in an extra year. I laboured for four years, studying nearly double the subjects, but I am now not getting a seat."

The ranking question. Students also question the use of CGPA as a criterion. "Why is CGPA a criteria? CGPA differences also appear from college to college. Some colleges may have a self-imposed unsaid ceiling of marks they award, and that automatically puts us at a lower footing then." DU has defended the ranking, saying the "difference between the two pathways" under the UGCF "begins at the onset of undergraduate admissions for itself", with Honours involving more stringent admission criteria. The university's Grievance Redressal Committee, in an order on September 9, held that there is a "difference in academic rigour" between students in single-discipline and multidisciplinary programmes.

No seat, high fees, and few options. Unsure of the best course, one graduate enrolled in a two-year MA in History at DU as a "safer option". He is also trying for the one-year programme through the School of Open Learning, but worries about how the two kinds of degree are valued. "An open degree has a different worth," he says.



op) Gaurav Sharma with Anshika Dubey and Priyansl

ENROLMENT IS FALLING. The Delhi University Principals' Association said around 30% of students opted for the fourth year in 2025-26, and only a limited number had so far shown interest for 2026-27.

WHY IT MATTERS — NEP 2020 implementation and the Undergraduate Curriculum Framework; multiple entry-exit and credit transfer; the gap between policy design and institutional capacity; equity implications of CGPA-based ranking across unequally resourced colleges. One of the strongest GS II education case studies available this year — a policy that created an entitlement it could not supply.

THE NUMBERS BEHIND THE TRAP

FIGURE	COUNT
Applied to DU's UG programme, 2022	2.5 lakh
Admitted to the 2022 UG programme	72,600
Opted to continue into the fourth year	23,000
Applied for the one-year PG programme	14,000
Seats initially announced	1,063
Seat matrix after revision	~3,000
Admitted in the 1-year PG regular course	1,800
Left in limbo, an academic year lost	**~4,000**

"The much-touted programme has not worked as intended. The problems with this framework can't be resolved through minor changes."

AN ASSOCIATE PROFESSOR OF ENGLISH, KIRORI MAL COLLEGE

GS II · CAMPUS GOVERNANCE

Film institute students call for nationwide protests



Students distribute food as the canteen remained closed amid protest at SRFTI campus. EXPRESS

is easy to tackle and manipulate. We will not let them do that. We have a vice-chancellor who is address caste discrimination and institutional discrimination in educational institutions.

Students distribute food as the canteen remained closed amid protest at the campus. EXPRESS

Students of a film and television institute in Kolkata called for a nationwide campus protest on October 27 against what they called the "saffronisation of educational institutions", as their agitation entered its 28th day.

Addressing a press conference, they called upon student unions, universities and colleges across the country to join them in protest against "growing suppression of dissent". One rusticated student said: "We have a vice-chancellor who is spreading fake narratives against students. We see a similar pattern in Jamia Millia Islamia, Jawaharlal Nehru University, Jadavpur University..." Their demands include withdrawal of the National Education Policy 2020, an end to privatisation and surveillance of campuses, and that student union elections be held for successive terms, with the **Rohith Vemula Act** enacted to address caste discrimination and institutional discrimination in educational institutions.

The institute's registrar said rustications followed violations of bye-laws and standards of student conduct, and were recommended by the Dean's Council after a Fact-Finding Committee examined the incidents. The institute said disciplinary actions were related to specific acts of misconduct, vandalism and physical assault, and that any attempt to link these to students' legitimate exercise of their right to protest misrepresents both the facts and the specific grounds on which proceedings were initiated.

WHY IT MATTERS — Caste discrimination in higher education and the demand for a Rohith Vemula Act; disciplinary process and natural justice on campus; autonomy of centrally funded institutions.

THE LEAD · GS II

Saudi says Riyadh airport partly reopened despite Houthi threat

Missile shrapnel injures two and damages buildings and vehicles; the Houthis say the airport remains a target and urge travellers to stay away



ials inspect debris from ballistic missile interceptions in shidiyyah, near Mecca, on Saturday. REUTERS

NEAR MECCA — Officials inspect debris from ballistic missile interceptions in Ar Rashidiyyah on Saturday. REUTERS

Saudi Arabia said its main airport resumed operations at two terminals even as Yemen's Iran-aligned Houthis vowed to keep striking the facility, saying it remained a "military target".

King Khalid International Airport halted operations on October 10 following an attack claimed by the Houthis that killed 13 people, the deadliest in the kingdom in more than a decade. Saudi Arabia intercepted another wave of missiles and drones on Sunday as fighting with the militant group continued unabated.

Late on Saturday, the airport said Terminal 1 would be designated for domestic flights and Terminal 2 for international flights operated by national carriers starting Sunday. Despite the announcement, flight tracking data showed little traffic at the airport.

The Saudi-led coalition said earlier this month the Houthis had carried out 20 attacks on the airport between October 1 and 11. Saudi civil defence said Sunday shrapnel from the interception of two ballistic missiles launched by the Houthis over two areas injured two people and damaged residential buildings and vehicles.

The conflict has become an increasingly destabilising element in the US-Israeli offensive against Iran, turning US ally Saudi Arabia into a pressure point in the wider war.

Pakistan reopens key border with Iran. Pakistan has reopened a key border crossing with Iran to resume bilateral trade and cross-border movement after a week-long suspension that stranded freight vehicles and disrupted supplies, the president of the Gwadar Chamber of Commerce and Industry confirmed.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Spillover of the Iran conflict onto Gulf energy and aviation infrastructure; the Houthis as a non-state actor with cross-border reach; implications for India's Gulf diaspora, remittances and air connectivity.

GS II · US–IRAN

With Iran, Trump weighs harder strikes or a deal

The US President bristled when asked how far he was from a possible attack on Iran. He recently said on social media he would not hit Iran again before the November 3 midterm elections. "Do you really think I'm going to tell you if I'm going to do it?" he told reporters. "And there's a possibility I will. There's also a possibility we'll have a nice, big, beautiful agreement."

Meanwhile, the Iranian President accused Washington of disrupting negotiations to end the war but said he still believed "we have to go and finish it". In comments aired on state television, he said Iran's supreme leader had instructed Iranian officials to "go and finish it (the deal)", but "these scoundrels broke the rules of the game. We were holding talks, and they disrupted them".

ANALYSIS · GS II

In the Iran war, no clarity on what a win might look like

BY A FORMER ARMY COMMANDER, CHINAR CORPS

Eight months into the war, US and Israeli strikes have damaged Iran's military infrastructure, yet Tehran retains the ability to threaten regional security and shipping. Overwhelming American superiority has not delivered a decisive political outcome.

The November 3 midterms may influence the US President's choices, but cannot replenish munitions or resolve Washington's uncertain objectives. **Does America seek to eliminate Iran's nuclear capability, dismantle its missiles, secure Hormuz, or change Tehran's behaviour? Each demands a different strategy.** Regime change would require far more. Without clarity, further military escalation may merely prolong the conflict.

Supply chains challenge assumptions about isolation. Iran's northern land borders, Caspian access and overland commercial routes receive little attention compared with its vulnerable southern coastline. Across West Asia, ISIS and the Houthis have demonstrated how weapons move through indirect networks despite surveillance, hostile borders and maritime interdiction. Iran's requirements are far greater than those of insurgent organisations, making direct comparisons imperfect. The question is how quickly Iran can restore sufficient capability to remain dangerous.

The US faces its own industrial problem. Reports of exceptionally heavy expenditure of Patriot interceptors, alongside other precision munitions, underline the mismatch between the speed of consumption and the years sometimes needed for replenishment. America must also maintain commitments to Ukraine and preserve readiness for contingencies in the Indo-Pacific.

Iran's endurance has limits. Inflation, disrupted trade, reduced revenues and civilian hardship can gradually erode the state's freedom of action. But economic distress does not automatically produce political collapse. A country can remain militarily disruptive long after its society has suffered greatly. Ultimately, the ability to end a war on acceptable terms is a greater measure of military success than the ability to prolong it.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — War termination theory and the definition of victory; sanctions and strategic endurance; defence-industrial capacity as a constraint on great powers. Excellent conceptual framing for GS II and essay answers on the limits of military force.

ELECTION SEASON

Polls in Israel test Netanyahu's grip on his once-loyal supporters

In the remote Negev Desert town of Dimona, long a bastion of the Prime Minister's Likud party, disenchanted voters are going door-to-door campaigning for his top rival, hoping to convince their community to vote for the former chief of the General Staff of the Israel Defence Forces.

The ballot is Israel's first since the October 7, 2023 attack that shook the country and plunged the region into turmoil. "We must have change. Bibi has to go," said one 74-year-old who says he has supported Likud most his life. It is a tough task in Dimona, where half the voters in the previous 2022 election cast a ballot for Likud.

The October 7 security breach saw Likud's popularity plummet. Opinion polls for months have predicted the Prime Minister's coalition of right-wing, far-right and ultra-Orthodox parties losing its majority. But his top rival, the centrist challenger, has no clear path to power either, and the race has become tighter as the election nears.

The Mizrahi factor. Right-wing Likud long ago formed a core voter base among Jews of West Asian and North African descent, known as Mizrahis, who felt neglected by the European-influenced centre-left Labor Party that dominated Israel for generations. Some **13%** of Israeli voters have yet to decide how they will vote; of those who voted for Likud in 2022, just 55% now say they will vote for the party again. Fifteen percent will support parties aligned against Netanyahu, including 8% for the centrist challenger. Another 14% will vote for alternative right-wing parties, and 9% are undecided.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Proportional representation and coalition politics in Israel; the Knesset's 120 seats and the threshold problem; how domestic electoral calculus shapes conflict behaviour. Note the analytical point: an anti-incumbent verdict need not change the Palestinian question.

IN BRIEF

Ukraine refutes Musk's claim of Starlink terms violation

Ukrainian officials disputed claims by the SpaceX chief executive that the country's military violated Starlink's terms of service by using the civilian satellite internet network for offensive drone strikes. A defence technology adviser to the President said long-standing restrictions on the civilian system in Ukraine made such offensive use impossible: drones connected to Starshield took connectivity at high speeds, disrupting air defences during daily Russian air attacks. Officials said the so-called speed caps were lifted on Saturday, and the service was restored.

Kenya: bus carrying funeral-goers rams into truck, 24 killed

A bus collided with a truck on Kenya's main highway on Sunday. The National Transport Safety Authority suspected improper overtaking.

GS II · INDIA AND THE WORLD

Terror as statecraft unacceptable, not all show zero tolerance: EAM



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar addresses 75th Chinmaya Amrit

NEW DELHI — The External Affairs Minister addresses a global gathering on non-dualism on the occasion of UN Day on Sunday.

Without naming Pakistan, the External Affairs Minister said that the use of terrorism as an instrument of statecraft was unacceptable, calling for a strong global resolve to counter terrorism in all its forms and manifestations.

"If something that matters so deeply to us, there isn't enough understanding or appreciation or empathy of that, I think that creates a problem too," he said, while speaking of decades of attacks originating in all its forms and manifestations.

"Terrorism is another deadly threat to peace. Its usage as an instrument of statecraft is simply unacceptable. It can never be rationalised. It continues because not all states really display zero tolerance," he said.

A few weeks ago, speaking at a conversation hosted by the Asia Society in New York, he had said that terrorism emanating from its neighbour is one of India's primary concerns, and if this is not fully appreciated by India's partners, it affects bilateral ties.

On UN reform. During his address, he spoke on the need for reforms in the United Nations, emphasising that the shortcomings and limitations of the global body must be recognised and addressed, and that the case for reformed multilateralism was becoming stronger by the day. "Large parts of the world cannot be left out from decision-making. The UN must show leadership, not be a spectator to global crises."

He pointed to two major conflicts going on in the world, in Ukraine and in West Asia: "Societies and economies, peoples far away, who have little say in the matter, are equally indivisible. The world cannot advance half prosperous and half denied in an era of intricate supply chains, of globalised markets, and of common resources. This is simply a prescription for continuous instability."

A day earlier, India condemned the attack on a church in Jordan's Karak, which claimed seven lives and left 34 injured, terming the strike a "heinous" and "cowardly" act.

WHY IT MATTERS — State sponsorship of terrorism in international law; UNSC reform and the G4; India's framing of "reformed multilateralism"; the Comprehensive Convention on International Terrorism still pending at the UN.

LATIN AMERICA

Lula and Bolsonaro face off in a tight second round in Brazil

Brazilians voted on Sunday in a tight runoff vote that could shift Latin America's largest nation sharply rightward, bringing it closer to the United States as part of a broader conservative shift across the region.

The runoff pits the leftist incumbent against a right-wing Senator, the son of a convicted former President. The challenger scored a major upset at the start of the month by defying pollsters to lead voting in the first round. A victory for him would extend a wave of right-wing victories for Latin American candidates friendly to the US President, while a fourth mandate for the incumbent would be a disappointment in Washington, which has clashed with his government over trade and security.

Brazil's election race has been dominated by corruption scandals, economic anxiety and accusations of US meddling — which Washington denies. It has also been coloured by fallout from the former President's 2025 conviction for plotting a 2022 coup, with his son pledging to free his father if elected. While this was later watered down, the US imposed new levies against Brazil this year, citing unfair trade practices.

WHY IT MATTERS — Great-power competition in Latin America; BRICS cohesion if leadership changes; trade coercion through tariffs as a foreign policy instrument.

EUROPE & THE AMERICAS · IN BRIEF

Serbia votes in historic polls as students seek to end Vucic's reign

Serbian voters turned out in force on Sunday as a mass student protest movement sought to unseat the long-time populist leader in the biggest challenge to his rule for more than a decade. The snap parliamentary elections come after almost two years of student-led demonstrations against perceived corruption and authoritarianism, triggered by the deaths of 16 people when a train station canopy collapsed in the city of Novi Sad in 2024. Unusually long lines snaked from polling stations; pollsters and monitors put turnout at 27.3% by 11 am, nearly double the 15.1% at the same time in the previous election in 2023.

Opposition leader Machado is back in Venezuela

The Venezuelan Opposition leader and Nobel Peace Prize winner has returned to the South American nation after nearly a year outside the country. "I'm here. With you all," she wrote on social media. Her return risks straining ties with the US administration, which she has sought to cultivate as an ally since before it removed the former President from power in January.

Kim emerges at the new Yalu River Bridge

The North Korean leader was seen accompanied by a member of the Standing Committee of China's Communist Party and the Chinese Foreign Minister at a send-off ceremony at the new bridge connecting the two countries, after his visit to Dandong in northeast China's Liaoning Province.

Obama slams Trump over White House renovations

Campaigning ahead of the November 3 midterms, the former President accused the administration of "emphasising unimportant matters" and argued that the war in Iran gave Washington less economic leverage because its threats to attack shipping in the Strait of Hormuz have unsettled oil exporters. "Iran now has veto power over the Strait of Hormuz, where oil goes through to get to the world," he said.

IDEA EXCHANGE · GS II BILATERAL

'Engage in political debate, but exploitation of political issues has no place in democracies'

THE GERMAN AMBASSADOR TO INDIA



ON RUSSIA'S REVISIONISM

If Putin gets his way in Ukraine, Russia will feel encouraged to move on towards the west. That's why we Europeans work so hard and why we have put sanctions in place. We are defending our own freedom and sovereignty

The newly appointed German Ambassador, who served in Moscow, Baku and Berlin from 1995 to 2009 and later at NATO in Brussels.

On priorities. "My first priority is to see the signing of the Free Trade Agreement between the European Union and India at the end of this year. The task is to tap into the potential of this FTA, we have to facilitate matchmaking between interested companies. The second priority is to focus on the implementation of our **Migration and Mobility Partnership Agreement**, which helps Indians come to Germany, find jobs there and become part of our society. Each year, we issue roughly 60,000 long-term visas in India; this includes visas for students as well as their families. In my first term, when I came to India in 2017, there were 17,000 Indian students enrolled in German universities, now we are at 70,000. My third priority is our defence and security partnership, in particular deepening our defence industrial cooperation."

On Russia's revisionism. "If Putin gets his way in Ukraine, Russia will feel encouraged to move on towards the west. That's why we Europeans work so hard and why we have put sanctions in place. We are defending our own freedom and sovereignty." Germany spent hardly 1.1 per cent of its GDP on defence in 2015, one year after Russia had annexed Crimea, when Russia, so they claim, felt threatened by NATO. "Russia's inherent revisionism was stronger than its readiness to become part of a united Europe."

On civic protests. "There was always a dialogue. That's what makes our societies different from authoritarian countries, where protests are suppressed. That can lead to grave mistakes by the ruling class because they don't accept any criticism. It is important that we all engage in necessary political debate, but at the same time violence or exploitation of political issues has no place in democracies."

On doing business with China. "German companies have benefited from engaging with China. By producing in China, our supply chains have been cost effective and the consumer has benefitted as well. But we also had to learn our lessons and had to become more vocal with regard to reciprocity in investment opportunities and fairness in trade. Our economy had become too dependent on China. We now have investment screening mechanisms in place and encourage companies to diversify. This also explains the rising importance of India to German business and the FTA between India and the EU."

WHY IT MATTERS — India–EU FTA and the Migration and Mobility Partnership Agreement; de-risking versus decoupling from China; NATO burden-sharing and European defence spending; Indo-German defence industrial cooperation.

12.5%
Current uniform long-term capital gains tax rate, effective July 23, 2024, now under review for the coming Budget.

22.2%
Fall in sales of complex fertilisers, April–September 2026 over the same period last year — the sharpest drop.

₹1.71 lakh cr
Fertiliser subsidy budget for 2026-27; the Hormuz disruption could push it to ₹2.5–3 lakh crore.

67%
Surge in pulse imports in April–August to 2.06 million tonnes, amid concerns over a dip in domestic output.

18.6%
Operating margin of a large IT services firm, as AI-led revenue rises but overall growth stays muted.

EXPRESS INTERVIEW · GS III

‘Rupee much more flexible now, FX rate should be the first line of defence’

Reaping the dividends of demography requires addressing the skill mismatch, says the IMF’s Director for Asia and the Pacific



The Director of the Asia and Pacific Department, International Monetary Fund.

There has been “much more flexibility” in the rupee’s exchange rate after its *de facto* arrangement was reclassified last year as ‘crawl-like’ from ‘stabilised’, the IMF official said in an interview.

“They have allowed the exchange rate to move... There is definitely much more flexibility in the exchange rate, no question about that. The IMF’s **Article IV** team will look at that (exchange rate classification). It’s a very mechanical exercise. But the point I want to make is that the exchange rate has been a lot (more) flexible since the time when that assessment was made.”

WHY IT MATTERS — IMF Article IV consultations and exchange rate classification; managed float versus free float; the demographic dividend and the skills question; AI’s labour-market effects. A rich source of precise phrases for GS III answers.

FROM PLATE TO PLOUGH · GS III

We need to address the issue of soil health. Four steps can improve the situation

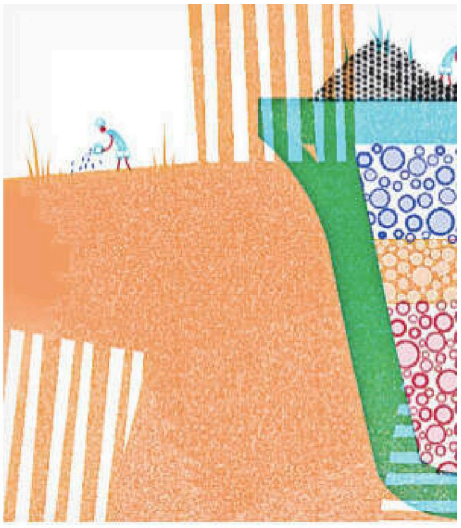


Illustration: C R Sasikumar

The Union Minister for Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare launched a *rabi* campaign, "Khet Bachao Abhiyan" (Save the Farm Campaign), on October 22 in Karnal, Haryana. The focus is to correct the imbalanced use of chemical fertilisers, which is harming soils and groundwater and polluting the air.

The imbalance. Sixteen years after the **Nutrient Based Subsidy (NBS)** was introduced, the imbalance in the use of nitrogen (N), phosphate (P) and potash (K) has worsened. The NBS let the prices of phosphatic and potassic fertilisers float with world markets, but kept urea out at a fixed price. Between 2010-11 and 2024-25, DAP prices nearly tripled to ₹54/kg, and MOP rose six-fold to ₹52/kg, while the price of nitrogen in urea rose by just 1 per cent. Farmers respond to relative prices. The **N:P:K ratio stands at 10.5:4.1:1**, against a desired normative **2.8:1.5:1**. Eleven of 20 major states, led by Jharkhand (72 per cent) and Punjab (65 per cent), overuse nitrogen.

The damage. Nationally, nitrogen use has moved from 7 per cent below its recommended dose to 6 per cent above it. Of the 96 lakh samples tested under the Soil Health Card scheme in 2025-26, **72 per cent were low in nitrogen, 52 per cent in organic carbon, 42 per cent in boron and 37 per cent in zinc**. Nitrate above safe limits has been found in parts of 502 districts and carries the risk of "blue baby syndrome" in infants and chronic illness in adults.

Four steps. One, move from input price subsidy to a **direct benefit transfer on a per-hectare basis** and neutral across nutrients and crops. AgriStack is creating digital farmer IDs linked to land records, and a framework for fertiliser sale to tie each purchase at the point of sale to that identity. Two, **rebalance where decisions are made** — PM-PRANAM was supposed to reward states that use fertilisers in a balanced way, but nothing has been disbursed. Three, **channel savings into drip irrigation and fertigation, and into product innovation** — customised and coated fertilisers, triple super phosphate (TSP, in place of DAP), bio-fertilisers, nano fertilisers and gene-edited seeds. Four, **follow the 4Rs** — right source, right rate, right time and right place — with plot-level advice based on soil tests. Rotating cereals with pulses can cut the next crop's nitrogen need by 20-30 per cent.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — The Nutrient Based Subsidy and urea price control; the N:P:K imbalance and its environmental cost; Soil Health Card data; PM-PRANAM; DBT reform in fertiliser subsidy; the 4R nutrient stewardship framework. One of the most answer-ready GS III agriculture pieces of the year.

GS III · INSURANCE

Insurance agents blame hospital and garage costs for rising premiums

Skyrocketing hospital bills and inflated motor garage repair costs, rather than insurance agents' commissions, are driving up general insurance claims and putting pressure on premiums, the Confederation of General Insurance Agents Associations of India has said, urging the government to tackle the root causes of rising costs instead of squeezing insurance distribution.

"The primary driver of rising premiums is the industry's steep **84% to 87% incurred claims ratio**, fuelled by systemic price inflation," the association said, arguing that the focus of regulatory reform should be on the costs insurers incur when settling claims.

The association alleged that hospitals frequently charge insured patients substantially more than those paying cash for comparable treatment. It also claimed that automobile workshops significantly inflate repair estimates when bills are routed through insurance. "When a family is stranded at a hospital billing counter or standing by a damaged vehicle on a highway, an automated chatbot or call centre algorithm cannot replace the local insurance agent who physically visits, advocates, and secures fair settlement."

It has warned that proposed reforms by the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India, including tighter expense-of-management caps, risk weakening consumer protection while threatening the livelihoods of those who help policyholders navigate claims.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — IRDAI and expense-of-management norms; the incurred claims ratio as an industry metric; information asymmetry and differential pricing in healthcare; financial inclusion through intermediaries.

BRIEFLY

Government extends deadlines for annual returns

The corporate affairs ministry extended the deadline for companies to file their annual financial statements for the fiscal 2025-26 till December 31. Companies can submit annual returns till January 31, 2027.

SBI cracks down on dormant accounts

The bank plans to close inoperative savings accounts with zero balances to curb fraud and prevent their misuse as mule accounts for routing illicit funds.

Five companies to launch IPOs this week

Five companies are set to launch initial public offerings, seeking to raise close to ₹2,600 crore from the primary market.

THE IDEAS PAGE · GS III INFRASTRUCTURE

Twenty-five years of reshaping how the state thinks about infrastructure

The change is conceptual: infrastructure creation was once approached in a piecemeal manner, with a ministry, department or agency responsible for individual projects



AJIV GAUBA

n public life, first as Gujar
ne Minister, Narendra M

The writer is a member of NITI Aayog and a former Cabinet Secretary.

India's airport network has more than doubled. The railway system has seen major expansion and modernisation, from dedicated freight corridors and electrification to the high-quality experience offered by Vande Bharat trains and redeveloped railway stations. National highways have expanded substantially, and new expressways, ports and metro systems have transformed the country's connectivity landscape.

While these changes have rightly attracted considerable attention, a more fundamental change is conceptual. Previously, infrastructure creation was approached in a piecemeal manner, with a ministry, department or agency responsible for individual projects.

The user's view. Citizens or businesses, however, do not experience infrastructure along departmental lines. A person commuting to work, a farmer transporting crops to a *mandi*, or a manufacturer managing a supply chain relies on roads, railways, ports, water, and power as an integrated system. When even one link in this chain is weak or missing, the return on every other investment and ease of living suffers.

Rather than looking at infrastructure solely through the lens of the department responsible for delivering a particular asset, the focus is on the larger outcome it is meant to achieve. This outcome-oriented, citizen-centric perspective has been a hallmark of this approach to administration.

Gati Shakti. Did government departments not coordinate before? Of course they did. But there is a fundamental difference between the coordination that governments have traditionally practised and the approach Gati Shakti seeks to institutionalise. Instead of discovering interdependencies when they spark a conflict on the ground, planners now identify them while projects are still on the drawing board. Before a road is designed, what else is slated for that corridor? If a port is meant to serve a wider region, how will its hinterland be connected, and can these investments be sequenced so that one is ready the moment the other goes live?

PRAGATI. Planning is only one part of the challenge; effective execution is equally important. Infrastructure projects can encounter a range of bottlenecks during implementation, whether related to land acquisition, statutory clearances, shifting of utilities, law and order, or coordination between different ministries and between the Centre and the states. PRAGATI was conceived to address these challenges by bringing the relevant authorities together to review projects, resolve implementation issues and accelerate delivery.

Ultimately, the significance of 25 years in public office lies not just in the physical assets built on the ground, but in how the state has reshaped the way it thinks about infrastructure. A state that takes a system-level approach, firmly anchored in providing a seamless experience to citizens, is improving the productivity of the wider economy.

WHY IT MATTERS — PM Gati Shakti National Master Plan and the National Logistics Policy; PRAGATI as a review mechanism; multi-modal connectivity; the shift from output to outcome budgeting. Strong GS III infrastructure material with named mechanisms.

GS III · RENEWABLES & LAND

Agrivoltaics: can India put solar panels on farms without hurting crop yields?

olar panels on farms



Agri-photovoltaics involves installing solar panels on elevated structures over agricultural land. REUTERS

Agri-photovoltaics involves installing solar panels on elevated structures over agricultural land. REUTERS

The government this week announced plans to introduce **agri-photovoltaics (PV)** under the second phase of the **Pradhan Mantri Kisan Urja Suraksha evam Utthaan Mahabhiyan (PM-KUSUM)**, its flagship scheme to solarise irrigation. The approach combines solar power generation with crop cultivation on the same land, with the aim to allow farmers to continue growing crops while earning additional income from electricity generation.

The Union New and Renewable Energy Minister said the approach could help address the shortage of land for solar projects while allowing farming to continue beneath elevated panels. Citing estimates, he said around **30% of India's 160 million hectares of cropland** could be suitable for agrivoltaic projects.

How it works. Agri-photovoltaics involves installing solar panels on elevated structures over agricultural land, allowing farmers to continue cultivation underneath while generating electricity from the panels. The difference lies in the additional infrastructure required to elevate the panels and leave sufficient space for farming activities beneath them. Panels are mounted at a height of around 3.5 to 4 metres above the ground.

Not all crops are suitable. While photovoltaic is suitable for fruits and leafy vegetables, it has not been found suitable for crops such as rice and sugarcane. The additional civil and structural infrastructure makes agri-photovoltaic projects around **25-30% more expensive** than conventional ground-mounted solar projects, according to officials. The potential capacity for agri-photovoltaics in India is estimated at **1-2 terawatts (TW) or 1000-2000 gigawatts (GW)**.

Concerns over crop yields and farmers' interest. Over 85% of India's farmers are small and marginal farmers, while the average landholding in the country is **0.96 hectare**. The policy must be designed to benefit small farmers and protect agricultural production. The model must ensure that farmers do not lose control of their agricultural land or suffer a decline in crop production. Since most projects are still at the pilot stage, their impact on farming must be assessed before they are scaled.

WHY IT MATTERS — PM-KUSUM and solarisation of agriculture; land-use competition between food and energy; the 500 GW non-fossil capacity target; small and marginal farmers as the unit of policy design. An excellent example of a technology whose viability depends on landholding structure.

GS III · ENERGY

Samudra Manthan: government to bear losses on dry oil wells

The government is offering oil and gas explorers a new financial arrangement to encourage drilling in India's deep seas: it will pay up to half the cost of an exploratory well and bear its share of the loss if no commercially viable oil or gas is found. However, companies making productive finds will have to repay the money, under the scheme.

Under the new arrangement, the government will share that financial risk, while companies will remain responsible for drilling operations and the remaining expenditure. According to the petroleum ministry's operational guidelines, the Centre will fund up to **50% of the actual drilling cost**, subject to a ceiling of **₹675 crore per well**. If drilling fails to find oil or gas, or discovers reserves that cannot be commercially produced, the government will not recover its contribution.

The move is aimed at tackling one of the biggest hurdles in offshore exploration: companies must spend hundreds of crores searching for oil and gas without any guarantee of a discovery. For successful wells, repayment will begin after seven years, with the money recovered through annual instalments from company revenue, without any adjustment for inflation or the time value of money.

WHY IT MATTERS — Energy security and import dependence; risk-sharing instruments in upstream exploration; the Open Acreage Licensing Policy and HELP framework as context.

GS III · TECHNOLOGY & SERVICES

AI revenue rises, but IT growth remains muted

Artificial intelligence is emerging as a significant revenue stream for Indian IT services firms, but its rapid growth is yet to translate into a meaningful acceleration in overall revenue as automation threatens to erode the traditional services business.

One large-cap firm reported the highest sequential revenue growth in constant currency terms at **2.3%** in the September quarter, followed by 0.5% and 0.3% at peers; another reported flat revenue growth. The modest performance came despite companies reporting strong growth in their AI-related businesses, highlighting the widening gap between the emerging opportunity and the pressures on their existing business.

One firm said AI now accounts for **10.5% of its revenue**, with the business growing 29% sequentially; another reported an annualised AI revenue run rate of **$3.1 billion**, crossing 10% of total revenue for the first time. A third firm's Advanced AI revenue, which includes intellectual property and platform components, rose 28% sequentially and contributed 6% of total revenue; the business also contributed 32 basis points to its operating margin of 18.6%.

The challenge. The industry has to generate enough new AI-led business to offset the revenue lost as clients demand greater productivity and lower costs. "Expectations for AI-led productivity commitments are increasing competitive intensity and reshaping commercial models," one CFO said during the company's earnings call. Companies are demanding measurable returns from technology spending while maintaining cautious discretionary expenditure, putting pressure on traditional contract values.

WHY IT MATTERS — Services exports and the IT sector's contribution to GDP and employment; productivity-linked pricing and the cannibalisation problem; AI as both a revenue line and a margin threat.

GS III · AVIATION

An airline seeks India growth through premiumisation



The airline is expanding premium economy amid rising demand for premium travel. REUTERS

A major Gulf carrier has stepped up its product premiumisation effort in the Indian market. From Sunday, it has expanded its premium economy offering to and from Delhi and Kolkata. It is also introducing its flagship A380 aircraft for the first time on one of its four daily frequencies from Delhi, making the capital the third Indian city to be served by the superjumbo.

The significance lies in the scale of the premium economy capacity expansion. The airline doesn't see this cabin class as a niche offering any more, and the premium economy product is becoming a more prominent component of its India network, giving the airline more opportunities to sell a higher-priced seat to passengers who might otherwise have travelled in the economy class. And not just in India, this cabin class is also gaining prominence in the airline's global fleet and network.

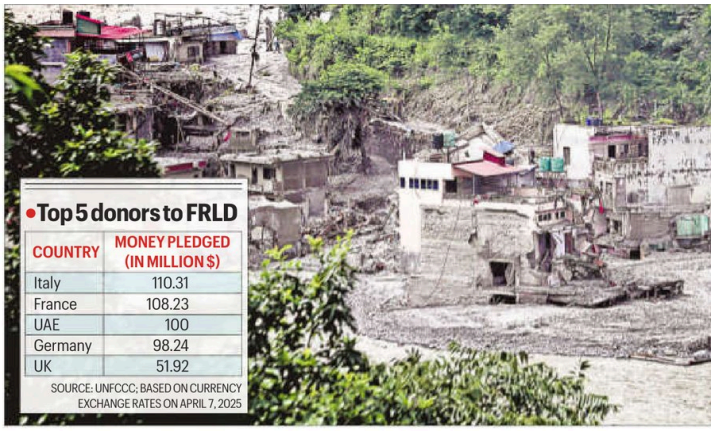
An analysis of airline capacity data from aviation analytics firm Cirium shows that the number of premium economy seats being offered by the carrier on its flights from India has shot up. In November, it is offering **50,264 premium economy seats per week** on its flights from India, up 80.2% over November of last year. As compared to September of this year, the November premium economy seat capacity is up 73.4%. Since 2022, when the airline offered just 784 premium economy seats per week, the number has risen sharply.

WHY IT MATTERS — Civil aviation and the sixth-freedom traffic question; Gulf carriers' share of India's outbound traffic; bilateral air services agreements as a policy lever. Useful for any answer on India's aviation hub ambitions.

EXPLAINED · CLIMATE FINANCE

Why the Loss and Damage Fund for Nepal matters beyond it

Developing nations have long pushed for payouts for events worsened by climate change. Nepal could become a template



The devastated structure around Betrawati Rasuwa border in Nepal following the flash floods on August 3

donor countries, the FRLD made its first call for applications during the annual climate

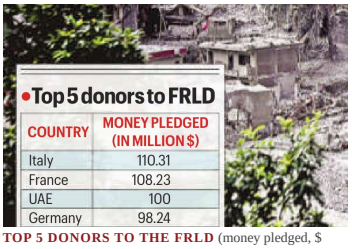
Huge demand, limited s

Most of the current requests r

BETRAWATI RASUWA BORDER — The devastated structure around the border in Nepal following the flash floods on August 31. FILE

A month after it raised a request, Nepal has been promised a sum of **$20 million** (around ₹190 crore) to help it recover from the devastating flash floods in August this year. Though the amount is extremely small compared to an estimated need of about **$4.75 billion** (around ₹44,600 crore) in recovery and reconstruction costs, it marks the beginning of the implementation of a new international regime on loss and damage.

The allocation is a first from the **Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage (FRLD)**, a new international financing instrument created in 2022 to address a long-pending demand from developing countries, particularly those small and vulnerable countries that face the maximum risk from climate events. These countries have contributed negligibly to creating the problem of climate change because of their extremely low emissions footprint, and yet, they suffer disproportionately from its consequences. For instance, Nepal's contribution to historical global emissions of greenhouse gases is a tiny **0.01%**.



TOP 5 DONORS TO THE FRLD (money pledged, $ million): Italy 110.31, France 108.23, UAE 100, Germany 98.24, UK 51.92. Source: UNFCCC, based on currency exchange rates as of April 7, 2025.

As a result, the fund will have to prioritise these requests. A decision on these requests is scheduled for December, although Nepal's case is a separate one. The flooding incident, in which more than **1,300 people were killed and over 5,000 continue to be missing**, happened in August, and an extraordinary request was made in September.

Under the global climate change architecture governed by the **UN Framework Convention on Climate Change** and the **2015 Paris Agreement**, developed countries are mandated to provide financial assistance to developing countries to help fight climate change. But just as they have been lacking in meeting their greenhouse gas emission reduction targets, developed countries have not fulfilled their financial obligations either.

This reluctance of developed nations to put money on the table has affected the loss and damage fund as well. These countries had stalled the creation of the fund for years, before giving in to sustained pressure. But the actual contributions to the fund have been minuscule: of a total of 27 donor countries, only three — Italy, France and the UAE — have made a commitment of over $100 million each. The FRLD does not have any target; countries are encouraged to contribute voluntarily.

Nepal's case is a small but important beginning. It opens up the possibility that immediate financial assistance could be provided to resource-scarce countries to respond to a major climate disaster. But over the long term, as such disasters become more frequent, the effectiveness of the FRLD would remain severely constrained unless developed nations put more money into the fund.

WHY IT MATTERS — The loss and damage debate from the Warsaw International Mechanism to COP27 and COP30; UNFCCC, the Paris Agreement and the New Collective Quantified Goal; climate justice and historical responsibility; India's own claims on the fund. Among the highest-probability GS III environment topics this cycle.

GS III · DISASTER MANAGEMENT

Odisha mobilises personnel, orders evacuations, braces for very severe cyclone

As the State braces for a very severe cyclonic storm that is expected to cross the Andhra Pradesh coast on **October 28**, the government on Sunday stepped up preparations, mobilising personnel and equipment in vulnerable areas.

In its latest bulletin, the India Meteorological Department said the depression over the Bay of Bengal is likely to cross the Andhra Pradesh coast between Bapatla and Visakhapatnam as a very severe cyclonic storm, with maximum sustained winds of **115-125 kmph and gusts up to 140 kmph**.

The Chief Minister said although the system was forecast to make landfall in Andhra Pradesh, the State would take no chances and remain fully prepared for any eventuality. In a circular, the government directed all additional chief secretaries, principal secretaries, commissioner-cum-secretaries and senior government officials to remain at their headquarters from October 26 to ensure administrative readiness and respond to any exigencies. In another circular, it cancelled the leave of all district collectors, district magistrates and other officers posted in critical offices.

The State has directed officials to evacuate people to safer locations. "Around **60 Odisha Disaster Rapid Action Force teams and 17 National Disaster Response Force teams** have been deployed, while **225 Fire Services teams** are on high alert," the Chief Minister said. Five districts bordering Andhra Pradesh are under a red warning for heavy to very heavy rainfall from October 27; the bulletin added that the system is "very likely to move north-northwestwards, intensify further into a very severe cyclonic storm and reach near the west-central Bay of Bengal around morning of October 28".

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — IMD cyclone classification and colour-coded warnings; NDRF, SDRF and ODRAF architecture; Odisha's zero-casualty model as a global reference; pre-emptive administrative mobilisation.

GS II · CLIMATE EDUCATION

At COP, a move from climate learning to climate action

The emergence of climate change education coincided with the growing recognition, since 2010, of climate change as a major developmental challenge. This called for a shift in understanding, as awareness had to expand beyond conservation to encompass resilience and sustainability.

Climate literacy in education was strengthened through the **National Education Policy (NEP) 2020** and the **National Curriculum Framework for School Education (NCF-SE) 2023**. The national-level **Mission LiFE**, rooted in climate change education (CCE), is undergoing a similar transition from awareness to action. Italy has systematically integrated climate change and sustainability as compulsory topics in schools, while the US state of New Jersey has incorporated climate change learning standards across multiple subjects and grade levels.

In India, this momentum found constitutional expression in the **42nd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1976**, which enshrined environmental protection as both a responsibility of the state and a duty of citizens. The real turning point in India's environmental learning journey, however, came with the Supreme Court's ***M C Mehta* judgment in 1991** — it directed that environmental literacy be made a compulsory component of formal education.

COP31, which begins on November 9 in Antalya, Turkey, is particularly important for sustaining this momentum. Around 100 countries and thousands of organisations have joined the initiative, which spans campuses, curricula and teacher training. Two areas require more attention: teacher capacity-building and the development of knowledge platforms for communities that share a common geography and face similar disasters. The UGC's *Guidelines and Curriculum Framework for Environment Education at Undergraduate Level* (2023) has a mandatory course that covers sustainability, climate policy, renewable energy and green technology.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Article 48A and Article 51A(g) via the 42nd Amendment; the *M C Mehta* (1991) direction on environmental education; NEP 2020 and NCF-SE 2023; Mission LiFE; COP31 at Antalya. Links environment with education policy — a crossover GS I/II/III theme.

EXPLAINED · ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

As AI solves complex maths problems, proof lies in the proving

The growing ability of artificial intelligence to solve mathematical problems is prompting researchers to rethink what constitutes progress in the field

In a lecture on October 9, the Fields Medallist Terence Tao argued that solving problems, historically one of the most visible goals of mathematical research, is only a means to broader ends. "Further blind optimisation of problem-solving alone is now actively harmful to the long-term health of mathematics," he said.

The debate comes as research institutions move to develop AI for mathematical discovery. For researchers, the challenge is not simply whether AI can generate proofs, but whether those results can be verified, understood and used to advance mathematical knowledge.

An assistant professor of computer science and engineering at IIT Delhi urged caution against both "celebration" and "doomerism". "Companies like OpenAI are expending millions of dollars' worth of compute and energy to produce these proofs," she said, raising questions about whether ordinary academics would have access to comparable systems.

What are proofs in research mathematics? In mathematics, it is not enough to find an answer. Researchers must also prove it. Take two even numbers: their sum will always be even. Trying this with a few numbers illustrates the pattern, but a proof explains why it must hold every time. Such proofs are the foundation on which mathematicians build new results. An error in one can undermine the work that follows.

Checking a proof can be surprisingly difficult. In his book *The Proof in the Code*, the author Kevin Hartnett recounts how the mathematician Tom Hales faced this challenge while proving the **Kepler conjecture**, which concerns the most efficient way to pack spheres together. Hales's proof involved hundreds of pages of mathematical reasoning and extensive computer calculations. After years of review, referees at *Annals of Mathematics* were unable to certify the proof as a whole, prompting Hales to look for a way to have a computer check it.

A shared repository. One such tool is **Lean**, a functional programming language and interactive theorem prover developed in 2013, which can be used to formalise mathematics and verify software. Mathematicians subsequently adopted it, building a shared digital library of definitions, theorems and proofs that others can reuse rather than start from scratch.

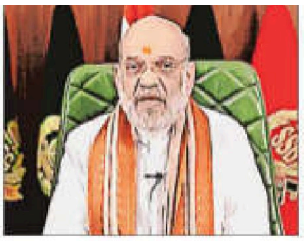
AI is beginning to ease this bottleneck through **autoformalisation** — the process of translating mathematical arguments from papers into formal code that a proof assistant can check. Hales wrote that it has now become "a practical reality".

Why does this matter now? On October 6, OpenAI released 722 AI-generated mathematical manuscripts on GitHub, grouped into 372 families of results. The repository now lists 300 of the 719 top-line results have been formalised in Lean. One researcher said an AI model may generate a sequence of mathematical steps, but not every step is necessarily valid. She added that Lean can help distinguish valid from invalid steps. Even this process, however, has limits: she pointed to examples of "junk" theorems that can be proved in Lean, underscoring that passing a formal check does not, by itself, establish a result's mathematical significance.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — AI in scientific discovery; verification versus generation; compute concentration and equity in research; formal methods and proof assistants. A sophisticated, quotable example for essays on AI and the nature of knowledge.

GS III · INTERNAL SECURITY

'India will hammer drug cartels': Shah hails Op Trident that unearthed hawala network



Union Home Minister Amit Shah

Congratulating the anti-narcotics team drawn from central agencies and the police forces of the three states, Shah said the

The Union Home Minister. PTI

Simultaneous raids across Assam, Mizoram and Manipur have led to the arrest of **18 people** and the freezing of **1,424 bank accounts**, exposing hawala transactions worth **₹100 crore** and rupturing the finances of a Myanmar-based drug lord arrested earlier this year, the Union Home Minister said on Sunday.

"Operation Trident" was carried out on **October 23** to dismantle an international narcotics cartel operating across India, Myanmar and Bangladesh. "The operation unearthed hawala transactions worth ₹100 crore and resulted in the seizure of 900 detonators and ₹12 lakh in cash," he said. "India will hammer until the last nail in the coffin of drug cartels."

He said the network trafficked narcotics across the borders of India, Myanmar and Bangladesh through the **"Death Triangle Corridor"**. Under the operation, the Narcotics Control Bureau, with 38 teams, raided 38 locations simultaneously across the three States, aiming to dismantle the operational and financial backbone of the cartel.

The raids followed days of covert intelligence fusion, joint target-mapping and high-level tactical briefings among central and state agencies; a government statement said they were designed to strike the syndicate's logistics nodes and illicit financial arteries at the same time. Multi-agency composite teams were mobilised concurrently across 38 pre-identified locations in the three states. "The strikes covered key urban hubs and sensitive border corridors, including a border trading town of Zokhawthar in Mizoram, along with linked operative bases in Churachandpur, Manipur, and the Cachar transit corridor in Assam."

The multi-state operation followed intelligence-led investigations by the NCB, the Mizoram Police and the Enforcement Directorate, tracing backward and forward links in cases selected for a **360-degree probe**. Despite challenging terrain and vast geographical spread, exceptional inter-departmental coordination ensured all searches, enquiries and financial audits were executed simultaneously, preventing the flight of suspects or concealment of illicit assets.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — The Golden Triangle and India's eastern border; the NDPS Act and the PMLA; NCB, ED and the drugs–terror–hawala nexus; the stated target of eradicating the drug network by December 31, 2029.

GS III · DEFENCE

'No permanent geographic split of fighter assets under theaterisation plan'



The Chief of Air Staff during the IAF Day Aerial Display 2026 in Varanasi on Sunday. PTI

In his first comprehensive articulation of the theaterisation plan, the Chief of Air Staff said on Sunday that the Indian Air Force is not in favour of permanently splitting fighter assets geographically, advocating instead for a tailored structure built around India's specific security requirements rather than replicating foreign models.

"The guiding principle should, therefore, be **centralised control where necessary, and decentralised execution where appropriate**. That way, air power can be concentrated where it is needed most, while commanders retain the agility to act swiftly on the ground," he said.

He highlighted how the joint structure during a recent operation produced desired results. "Our own experience bears this out. Under a joint architecture established by the Chief of Defence Staff, the centralised allocation and timely reallocation of critical resources proved decisive in the outcome."

He also called for avoiding the trap of trying to predict the future battlefield with **"excessive certainty"**. "As we design future structures, we must also avoid the trap of trying to predict the future battlefield with excessive certainty. What we can anticipate is that the next conflict will likely be faster, more autonomous, yet more network-dependent, more transparent, yet more deceptive and more precise in some respects, and characterised by mass in others. Our structures must be able to absorb that shift."

Announced in 2019 as India's most ambitious military reform since Independence, the theaterisation plan seeks to integrate the three services for greater operational synergy. The proposed architecture envisaged three integrated commands: a **Northern Theatre Command** focused on China, a **Western Theatre Command** to address challenges from Pakistan, and a **Maritime Theatre Command**. Progress has stalled due to divergent views among the three services over the proposed command structures.

"We are not viewing theaterisation as an exercise to permanently divide fighter assets geographically. The IAF is fully committed to jointness and integration," he said, asserting that air power remains India's primary responder to any security challenge.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Theaterisation and the Chief of Defence Staff; the Department of Military Affairs; integrated theatre commands and the inter-service debate; air power doctrine. Note the conceptual pair: centralised control, decentralised execution.

GS II · HEALTH GOVERNANCE

Cancer drug price cap: why India needs a bigger plan

BY A FORMER UNION HEALTH SECRETARY

The decision to regulate trade margins on non-scheduled cancer medicines is a welcome step. It responds to a genuine concern. In a welfare state, the government has a responsibility to ensure that healthcare is both accessible and affordable, while creating an environment in which quality care can be delivered sustainably. When the difference between the price at which a product enters the supply chain and what a patient ultimately pays becomes difficult to justify, the government cannot remain a passive observer.

The Centre has informed the Supreme Court that trade margins on specified cancer drugs will be **capped at 30 per cent**. An expert committee will identify the medicines to be covered, after which the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority will examine its recommendations. The court has also asked why similar scrutiny should not extend to other medicines and medical products.

The limits of a margin cap. That is a legitimate question. If excessive trade margins are the problem, India should examine the issue comprehensively rather than regulate one category at a time. A fragmented approach can shift distortions from one part of the market to another, create uncertainty and make enforcement needlessly difficult. But evidence must come before the prescription. The same medicine or medical product may cost different amounts to administer at two hospitals within the same city. The difference can arise from the patient's condition, the complexity of the treatment, the expertise of the treatment team, the infrastructure available, infection-control requirements, the level of monitoring involved and the emergency support that must remain available.

The procurement price of a medicine or device, therefore, tells us only one part of the story. A robust framework must distinguish between the trade margin on a product and the legitimate cost of storing, handling and administering it safely. It should also consider the infrastructure required to maintain quality and patient safety, and the possible effect of regulation on availability and access. Without this distinction, regulation intended to address excessive margins could inadvertently affect the delivery and quality of healthcare.

The government's own experience supports this approach. The 2019 trade-margin rationalisation pilot covered 42 selected non-scheduled anti-cancer medicines. Since then, consultations have raised concerns about production costs, the viability of smaller manufacturers and the cost of maintaining supplies in remote areas. Success cannot be measured merely by the number of products brought under control. The more meaningful test is whether patients pay fairer prices without experiencing shortages, reduced access or any compromise in the quality and safety of care.

WHY IT MATTERS — NPPA and the Drugs (Prices Control) Order; scheduled versus non-scheduled formulations; trade margin rationalisation; out-of-pocket expenditure and catastrophic health spending. A model GS II answer structure: welcome the step, then show why a single instrument is insufficient.

GS III · HEALTH & GENETICS

When genes raise cholesterol, diet may make a difference



A Chennai study has found that people with a higher genetic risk had higher levels of bad cholesterol when they followed a poor-quality diet, highlighting the role of everyday food choices in metabolic health

A Chennai study has found that people with a higher genetic risk had higher levels of bad cholesterol when they followed a poor-quality diet. GETTY IMAGES

A study of **1,020 adults** aged between 25 and 80, including 452 men and 568 women, in Chennai suggests that for Indians genetically predisposed to high levels of bad cholesterol or LDL, the quality of their everyday diet could make a crucial difference in their blood markers. Those who ate a medium- or high-quality diet could completely offset the genetic risk of high LDL and total cholesterol. Those who ate poorly ended up being susceptible to higher levels of both.

The researchers examined three genetic variants and scored diet quality using a **Diet Quality Score** covering eight food groups: pulses and legumes, fruits and vegetables, milk products, white rice, edible fats and oils, added sugar, added salt, poultry and eggs. The study, titled "Low diet quality increases the genetic risk of high blood cholesterol levels in Asian Indian adults", was published in *PLOS ONE*. It draws on data from the Chennai Urban Rural Epidemiology Study, a long-running research programme.

The researchers found that a higher genetic risk score was associated with significantly higher total cholesterol and LDL cholesterol among participants in the low diet-quality group. The differences were not statistically significant among those in the medium- and high-quality diet groups. The interaction between genetic risk and diet quality was statistically significant for total cholesterol and LDL cholesterol.

The study also found associations between the genetic risk score and higher fasting blood glucose as well as glycated haemoglobin (HbA1c), a measure of average blood sugar over the preceding two to three months.

The policy point. The findings offer an important message for people who believe that high cholesterol is an inevitable consequence of their genes: inherited susceptibility need not be the whole story. "While genes can influence a person's risk of metabolic disorders, dietary habits may modify how that risk manifests," the lead author said.

WHY IT MATTERS — Gene–environment interaction and the limits of genetic determinism; non-communicable diseases and India's nutrition transition; the ICMR-INDIAB study as a national data source; dietary guidelines as public health policy.

GS I · DEFENCE & HERITAGE

With an airshow over Varanasi's ghats, the IAF marks its 94th anniversary



Indian Air Force's Surya Kiran Aerobatic Team performs during the 'Wings Over Ganges' airshow in Varanasi on Sunday. PTI

The Surya Kiran Aerobatic Team performs during the 'Wings Over Ganges' airshow in Varanasi on Sunday. PTI

From the banks of the Ganga in Varanasi, the Prime Minister watched the 'Wings Over Ganges' airshow to mark the **94th anniversary** of the Indian Air Force. Along with French Rafale and Russian Sukhoi-30MKI, the indigenous **Tejas** fighter aircraft also showcased the IAF's operational capabilities over the Ganga.

The event brought together military aviation and Varanasi's cultural landscape, with aircraft formations flying over the ancient city's ghats. The display featured fighter jets, helicopters, transport aircraft and aerobatic formations, highlighting the IAF's combat readiness, precision flying and coordination across different aircraft platforms. The indigenous Tejas performed a series of manoeuvres, while the nine-aircraft **Surya Kiran** aerobatic team's synchronised aerial displays drew applause from spectators gathered along both banks of the river.

The programme also featured formations named after religious and cultural landmarks associated with Kashi, including 'Ganga', 'Vishwanath' and 'Dashashwamedh'. The show also included flying demonstrations by Mirage-2000, Jaguar and MiG-29 aircraft alongside transport and surveillance aircraft. A simulated aerial combat sequence illustrated the coordination and decision-making involved in air operations. An 'Omkar' formation of three Mi-17 V5 helicopters carried the national flag and the IAF flag.

WHY IT MATTERS — Indigenisation and the Tejas programme; the IAF's squadron strength debate; defence diplomacy and public outreach. Anniversary and ceremonial facts are standard prelims fare.

THE MAIN EDITORIAL ARGUMENT · GS III

The Starlink episode points to tightropes in a changing political economy

The question is whether India possesses sufficiently strong institutions to sustain competition when the commercial stakes are high and political influence is concentrated



RAJAT KATHURI

The writer is pro-VC and dean, School of Humanities and Social Sciences, Shiv Nadar University.

There is something deliciously ironic about a global satellite entrepreneur accusing one of India's largest conglomerates of oligarchic behaviour. One of the world's richest men has complained that one of India's richest is blocking Starlink's entry into the Indian market. The Indian government insists that Starlink is subject to the same regulatory requirements as its competitors, foreign or Indian.

Whether the accusation holds merit remains to be established, but the high-profile utterance raises questions that go well beyond satellite broadband. It touches on the character of Indian capitalism, its relationship with the state, and the changing political economy of globalisation.

India's inheritance. India's experience with capitalism has always been complicated by the relationship between business and the state. The much-derided **licence-permit raj** was initially justified by the scarcity of capital and the need to direct investment towards national priorities. In practice, it also created substantial opportunities for **rent-seeking**. The ability to obtain a licence, secure foreign exchange or negotiate an exception could be as important to commercial success as the ability to produce innovatively.

The American comparison. The vital point for this piece, however, is not to assert that every Indian fortune is indecorous, but simply that markets cannot be presumed to be competitive merely because ownership is private. An economy can liberalise extensively like we have and still retain formidable barriers to entry.

The lesson. The Starlink outburst brings these differences between India and America into sharp relief. Satellite broadband is a technologically demanding business, with huge fixed costs, vast economies of scale and potentially large benefits for remote areas. It is this aspect that is especially relevant for India. It is, however, also a sector in which security and international obligations necessitate regulatory responsibilities. Naturally satellite operators, whatever their identity, should be subject to regulation.

The question is whether India possesses sufficiently strong institutions to sustain competition when the commercial stakes are high and political influence is concentrated. Consumers are underserved in areas that may benefit and existing operators may discover that competition can once again stimulate innovation. However, a market is not genuinely open merely because a foreign entrepreneur has managed to enter it.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Crony capitalism and regulatory capture; competition policy and the Competition Commission of India; spectrum allocation and the *2G* jurisprudence on natural resources; satellite spectrum assignment (administrative versus auction). Among the best GS III political-economy arguments this month.

GS I · FEDERALISM & DEMOGRAPHY

A southern alliance, and an elephant in the room

The Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister apparently seeks to forge an informal "southern alliance" with his counterparts in Tamil Nadu, Telangana, Karnataka and Kerala towards building a **$10 trillion-plus bloc by 2047**. The five states together account for less than a fifth of India's population but over **31 per cent of its GDP, 35 per cent of factories and foreign direct investment equity inflows, and 26 per cent of total GST revenue collections**. Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Chennai house the country's busiest airports after Delhi and Mumbai, with Kochi at No. 8, just below Kolkata and Ahmedabad. Even more striking are the 2,100-odd global capability centres of the world's top multinational firms, employing nearly 2.4 million professionals — more than 80 per cent of these are in Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Chennai.

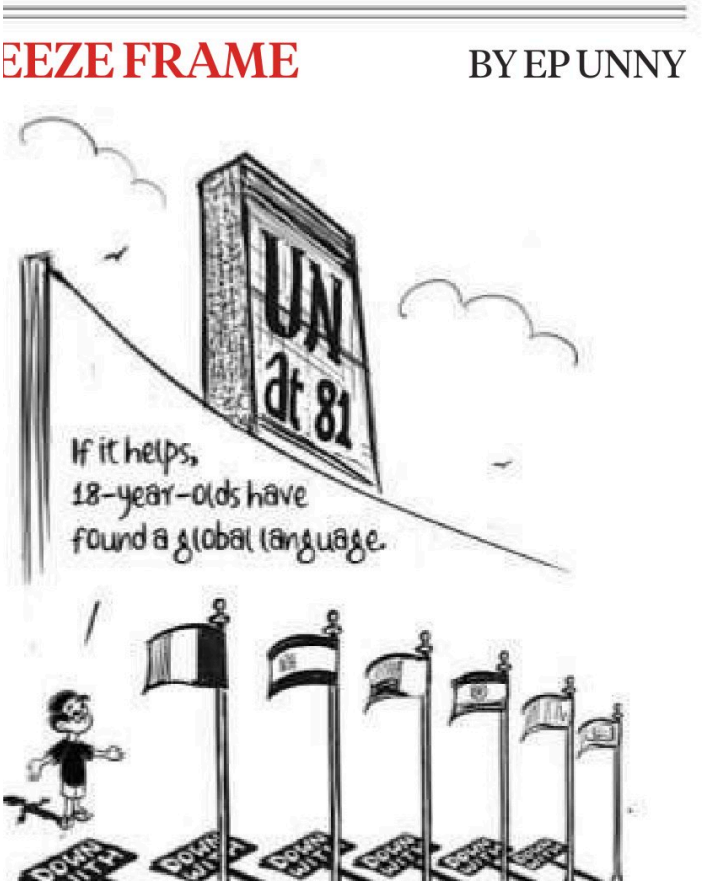
The structural weaknesses. The first is **ageing population**. The current median age in the five southern states, at 33-36 years, is more than the 30 years for all-India and 23-26 for Bihar and Uttar Pradesh. Roughly **19 per cent of Kerala's population and 16 per cent of Tamil Nadu's are aged above 60 years**, as against the national average of 11.4 per cent and 8.5-9 per cent for Bihar and UP. It translates into heavy reliance on migrant labour from the North and East — be it for factories, construction sites, office complexes, hotels or poultry farms. That isn't a bad thing, from a national integration standpoint. More concerning, however, is the fiscal position.

Tamil Nadu's outstanding liabilities of **₹10.4 lakh crore** (2025-26 budget estimate) exceed that of any state government. Andhra Pradesh's and Kerala's **debt-GDP ratios of 35.4-35.5 per cent** are higher than the 29.2 per cent average for all states. The southern states also have a **45 per cent share in the accumulated losses of state-owned electricity utilities**.

The South's problems partly resemble those of Europe: rapid population ageing and ballooning public debts. While some of that is due to sustained investments in public health care and education — which have helped lower fertility rates and raise life expectancies — there has also been a profusion of cash transfers, highly subsidised power and public transport, and other such schemes with low positive externalities. Unlike Europe, the South thankfully isn't facing economic stagnation. The proposed alliance would do well to address the elephant in the room: broken state finances that can derail the region's long-term growth prospects. It would add to the credibility of collective bargaining with the Centre, whether on fiscal devolution or delimitation.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Delimitation and the 2026 freeze expiry; the Finance Commission and fiscal devolution; regional demographic divergence; state debt sustainability and DISCOM losses. Among the most testable GS I/II federalism themes of the year.

FREEZE FRAME



By E P Unny.

GS I · SOCIETY

Young Europeans are protesting — not to reject, but to preserve

Across Europe, people are taking to the streets to protest against the rising cost of living, education and the growing difficulty of building a stable future. "As a young Belgian who has recently entered the workforce, I understand their frustration. We are told that hard work, education and ambition will allow us to build the lives we want."

In Belgium, buying a house with your partner and settling down has long been considered a step towards adulthood, often around the age of 30. This is becoming harder to attain without financial support from family. Recent figures suggest **six in 10 young homebuyers get such assistance**, compared with around three in 10 a decade ago. Financial security increasingly depends not only on hard work, but also on the circumstances into which one is born. Education faces similar pressures.

"There is no denying that governments must make difficult choices about public spending, debt and interest payments. But these decisions can have consequences for the opportunities available to the next generation. I do not believe our governments are deliberately making life harder for young people. Policymakers must balance competing priorities with limited resources."

There is, however, a distinction between legitimate protest and violence. Some individuals and organised groups exploit demonstrations to engage in vandalism and confrontation. Their actions can intimidate the public, create difficulties for police and overshadow the concerns of peaceful demonstrators. "I still value the stability, freedoms, public institutions and quality of life Europe offers. The protests should not be interpreted solely as a rejection of Europe or its governments."

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Intergenerational equity and the housing question; welfare retrenchment and democratic backlash; the distinction between protest and violence. Transferable to essay questions on youth, aspiration and the social contract.

CONSTITUTIONAL, LEGAL AND POLICY PROVISIONS IN TODAY'S NEWS

PROVISION / INSTRUMENT	WHAT IT SAYS — AND WHERE IT APPEARED
Article 316	Appointment and six-year term of members of a State Public Service Commission. *(Pg 4)*
Article 317	Removal of a PSC chairperson or member only by the President, after a Supreme Court inquiry on a reference and its recommendation. *(Pg 4)*
Article 131	Original jurisdiction of the Supreme Court in inter-State disputes — the Kotia cluster. *(Pg 4)*
Article 21	Life and personal liberty — the custodial death case and ₹25 lakh interim compensation. *(Pg 1)*
42nd Amendment, 1976	Inserted environmental protection as a duty of the state and of citizens (Articles 48A and 51A(g)). *(Pg 14)*
Section 72, Income-tax Act, 2025	Mode of computation of capital gains; sub-section (6) gives foreign currency conversion benefits to non-residents on unlisted shares and debentures. *(Pg 1)*
CEC & Other ECs Act, 2023	Appointment and conditions of service of the CEC and Election Commissioners; the immunity question. *(Pg 4)*
Lyngdoh Committee recommendations	Framework for student union elections — cited by both sides in the Jamia dispute. *(Pg 3)*
Nutrient Based Subsidy (2010)	Decontrolled P and K prices while urea remained price-controlled — the root of the N:P:K imbalance. *(Pg 10)*
PM-PRANAM	Scheme to reward states that reduce chemical fertiliser use; nothing disbursed so far. *(Pg 10)*
PM-KUSUM, Phase II	Solarisation of agriculture; agri-photovoltaics to be introduced under the second phase. *(Pg 13)*
FRLD (2022)	Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage, operationalised 2023; first call for applications at COP30. *(Pg 14)*
UNFCCC & Paris Agreement (2015)	Mandate developed countries to provide climate finance to developing countries. *(Pg 14)*
Sherman Act, 1890	The founding US antitrust statute — invoked in the Starlink political-economy argument. *(Pg 18)*
Drugs (Prices Control) Order / NPPA	Scheduled versus non-scheduled formulations; 30% cap on cancer drug trade margins. *(Pg 16)*
MMPA (India–Germany)	Migration and Mobility Partnership Agreement; ~60,000 long-term visas a year. *(Pg 9)*

CASES, REPORTS AND DOCTRINES

- **Supreme Court, March 11, 2026** — creamy layer status cannot rest solely on parental income; treating private-sector and PSU employees differently from government employees would be hostile discrimination.
- ***University of Kerala v Council of Principals, Colleges, Kerala*** **(2006)** — cited by Jamia protesters on student union elections.
- ***M C Mehta*** **(1991)** — directed that environmental literacy be a compulsory component of formal education.
- **Kepler conjecture** — the sphere-packing problem whose proof drove the turn to computer verification.
- **Diet Quality Score / CURES** — the Chennai Urban Rural Epidemiology Study underpinning the gene–diet cholesterol finding.
- **Theaterisation (announced 2019)** — three proposed commands: Northern (China), Western (Pakistan), Maritime.

TERMS, BODIES AND NUMBERS

- **ASDU** — absent, shifted, deceased or duplicate; the SIR classification behind 47.5 lakh 'uncollectible' Delhi entries.
- **Lean** — functional programming language and interactive theorem prover (2013); **autoformalisation** is translating proofs into machine-checkable code.
- **Death Triangle Corridor** — the India–Myanmar–Bangladesh trafficking route targeted by Operation Trident.
- **N:P:K ratio** — 10.5:4.1:1 actual against a normative 2.8:1.5:1; nitrous oxide is 273× as potent as CO_2.
- **4Rs** — right source, right rate, right time, right place.
- **Agri-PV** — panels at 3.5–4 m; 25–30% costlier than ground-mounted; potential 1–2 TW; average landholding 0.96 ha.
- **Incurred claims ratio** — 84–87% in general insurance; **EOM** caps are the IRDAI lever.
- **Article IV** — the IMF's annual consultation; the rupee reclassified from 'stabilised' to 'crawl-like'.
- **Gati Shakti and PRAGATI** — planning-stage interdependency mapping, and execution-stage bottleneck review.
- **GeM** — Government e-Marketplace; ₹250 crore of municipal purchases audited in MP.
- **Mizrahi** — Jews of West Asian and North African descent, a core Likud constituency.
- **Southern five** — under a fifth of population, 31% of GDP, 26% of GST; median age 33–36 against 30 all-India.

Mains Practice

1. A judgment delivered after a selection process has concluded creates obligations that cannot be met without unsettling the process itself. Examine with reference to the creamy layer determination in the civil services examination. *(GS II, 250 words)*
2. "Protected tenure is not a privilege of the office-holder but a safeguard for the institution." Discuss in the context of Articles 316 and 317. *(GS II, 150 words)*
3. A policy that creates an entitlement it cannot supply does more damage than one that promises nothing. Critically examine with reference to the four-year undergraduate programme and the one-year master's. *(GS II, 250 words)*
4. India's fertiliser subsidy does not merely cost money; it dictates what farmers put into the soil. Analyse the consequences and suggest reforms. *(GS III, 250 words)*
5. Agrivoltaics is a land-use solution in a country whose binding constraint is landholding size. Evaluate the prospects of agri-photovoltaics under PM-KUSUM. *(GS III, 150 words)*
6. The Loss and Damage Fund has established a principle but not a capacity. Discuss with reference to the first allocations and the state of climate finance. *(GS III, 250 words)*
7. "A market is not genuinely open merely because a foreign entrepreneur has managed to enter it." Examine the relationship between entry barriers, regulation and competition in India. *(GS III, 250 words)*
8. The southern states have solved the problems of growth and demography only to inherit those of Europe. Comment. *(Essay)*
9. When a machine can generate a proof but not establish its significance, what exactly has been automated? *(Essay)*

40 YEARS AGO · OCTOBER 26, 1986

Terror attack in a Punjab village: Seven people were killed and six seriously injured when three terrorists sprayed bullets from Sten guns in a busy market in a village in Abohar tehsil, Ferozepur district. The extremists came to the village on foot at around 7.30 pm and escaped on foot after the killings. The Home Minister left for the site following reports of the attack. **Pakistan to get AWACS soon:** The US administration was reported to have decided to clear sales of AWACS (Airborne Warning and Control System) to Pakistan — in what would be the most significant defence transfer to Pakistan at the time.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Punjab militancy in the 1980s and the road to the Rajiv–Longowal Accord; US arms transfers to Pakistan during the Afghan war. Both are standing modern-history and IR themes.

A CLOSING NOTE

Every item in this edition was selected from a single day's newspaper on one test: does it touch the UPSC syllabus? Sport, the crossword, Sudoku, jumbled words, horoscopes, comic strips, classifieds, tenders, financial results notices, display advertisements, local crime briefs and celebrity copy have all been removed. What remains has been re-written in brief, grouped by General Studies paper, and annotated with the syllabus link. Photographs and data are reproduced from the source edition for study use.

A UPSC-oriented digest. All items summarised in brief from the New Delhi edition of The Indian Express, 26 October 2026; please consult the original newspaper for full reports. Not affiliated with The Indian Express or with any examination authority.